THE PHRASE GUIDE · JUNIOR VS SENIOR

Say It Like a Senior.

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1 Send the bad news early

Bad news doesn't get better while you hold it. It just arrives with fewer options attached. The junior waits until he has the full picture. By then the picture includes a room full of people who heard it from someone else.

Don't say: *"Still looking into it. Update soon."* That sentence buys you a day and costs you the room. Say what slipped, what is blocking it, and the date you will have the new date.

> EXAMPLE
>
> *"The launch moves to the 14th. The API estimate is the blocker. I'll confirm the new date by Friday."*

2 Break the number apart

A junior guesses one number and spends the meeting defending it. A senior builds the number in layers, out loud, so anyone can follow it and anyone can fix one layer without burning the whole answer down.

Every delay message gets a date. Every estimate gets layers. If you don't have the date yet, give the date you'll have one.

> EXAMPLE
>
> *"Let me break it apart: market, segments, frequency. Here's my number, and here's how I'd check it."*

3 Change the weak part out loud

Pushback is part of the job. When someone challenges your number, they are handing you a better one. The junior argues. The senior takes the number, changes the one assumption he is least sure of, and keeps going.

Defending a guess makes the meeting about you. Changing it in the open makes the meeting about the answer.

> EXAMPLE
>
> *"You're right, 15% is high. At 10% the total is about 6 million. The rest of the layers hold."*

4 Ask what success looks like

"What's next?" is a junior question. It asks for tasks. The senior asks what done looks like before he touches the list, because the answer changes what goes first.

Ask it in planning. Ask it in the interview. Ask it in your first week. The question makes people picture you doing the job.

> EXAMPLE
>
> *"Before I prioritize: what does success look like for this launch, and how will we know?"*

5 Credit the catch

Someone finds your mistake in the review. The junior explains. The senior thanks them, fixes it, and moves on. The room remembers which one you were.

When someone catches your mistake, credit the catch. You just taught every engineer in the room that bringing you a problem is safe. That is worth more than being right was.

> EXAMPLE
>
> *"Good catch. That's on me. Fix goes in today, and I'll add the check to the review list."*

Check every message before you send it

Read each line and ask:

- [ ] Did I send the bad news, or am I still holding it?
- [ ] Does every delay carry a date?
- [ ] Did I break the number into layers anyone can follow?
- [ ] Did I change the weak assumption instead of defending it?
- [ ] Did I ask what success looks like before asking what is next?
- [ ] Did I credit the catch out loud?